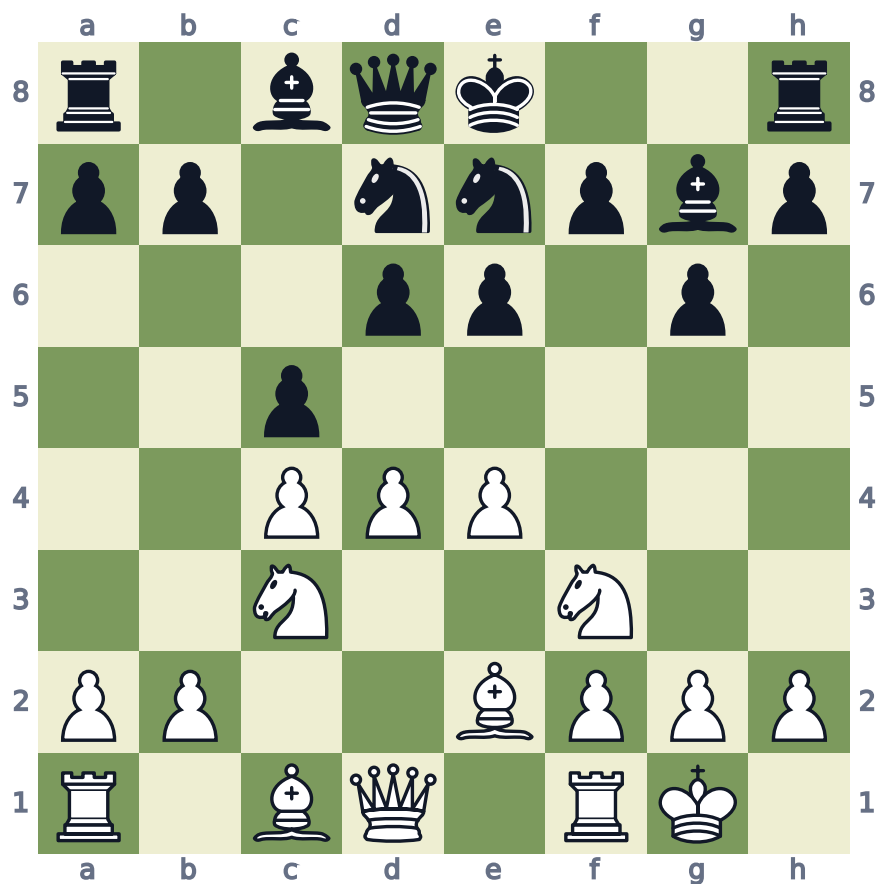


The Hippo c5 Break

Pressure on d4, Benoni-like closures, open c-files, and queenside counterplay



Use c5 as a precise attack on White's center and understand the resulting open, closed, and exchanged pawn structures.

8 learning units | solid-piece diagrams | recall tests | engine checks

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Use c5 as a precise attack on White's center and understand the resulting open, closed, and exchanged pawn structures.

THE HIPPO TRAINING LOOP

- First identify the center, both kings, and the opponent's most forcing pawn break.
- At every diagram, name the urgent threat and compare e5, c5, f5, and b5.
- Hide the answer until you have spoken the move, its purpose, and the opponent's best reply.
- Replay each branch from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected Black core repertoire. It teaches setup, exceptions, transformation, and resulting plans; the PGN companions make later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

c5 attacks the base of many d4-e4 centers.

PRINCIPLE 2

After d5, Black often gains queenside space but must watch e5.

PRINCIPLE 3

After dxc5, development and recapture method matter more than the pawn count.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

An open c-file can become the main counterplay route against queenside castling.

PRINCIPLE 5

The c-pawn should not move if c6 is needed for a knight or center restraint.

PRINCIPLE 6

Compare c5 with e5 by asking which White pawn is less well defended.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

- | | | |
|-----------|--|---|
| 01 | c5 against the broad d4 center | c5 asks the base of the center a direct question. |
| 02 | c5 in a double-fianchetto position | In fianchetto structures, the first useful diagonal often appears after c5. |
| 03 | c5 against the classical e4 center | Choose c5 when d4 is less stable than e4. |
| 04 | c5 against f4 | Central contact is the antidote to wing expansion only when it arrives on time. |
| 05 | c5 against long-castle development | If White may castle long, c5 gains an attacking purpose beyond d4. |
| 06 | c5 after Be2 | When both knights are compact, the break must create their next squares. |
| 07 | c5 in the English | Against c4-e4, c5 fights for d4 before White owns it. |
| 08 | c5 against a restrained Reti center | A quiet center should be challenged while its support is incomplete. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

c5 against the broad d4 center



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 Nd7 7. O-O c5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

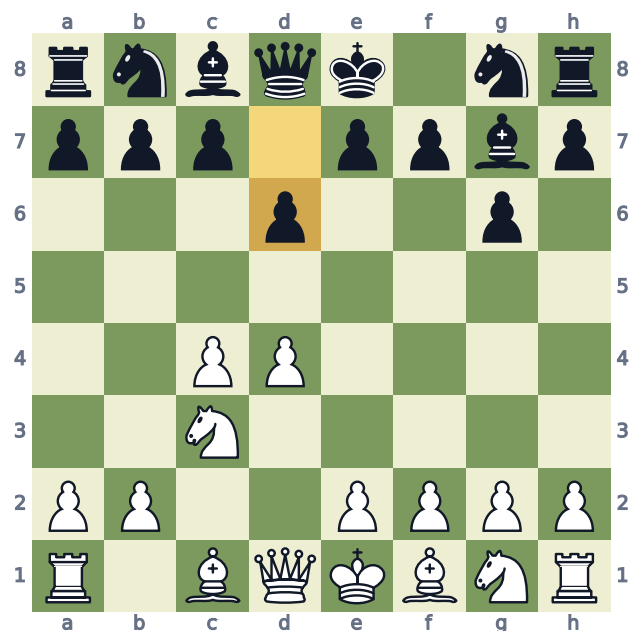
Attack d4 and open a queenside route for the rook and queen.

MAIN DANGER

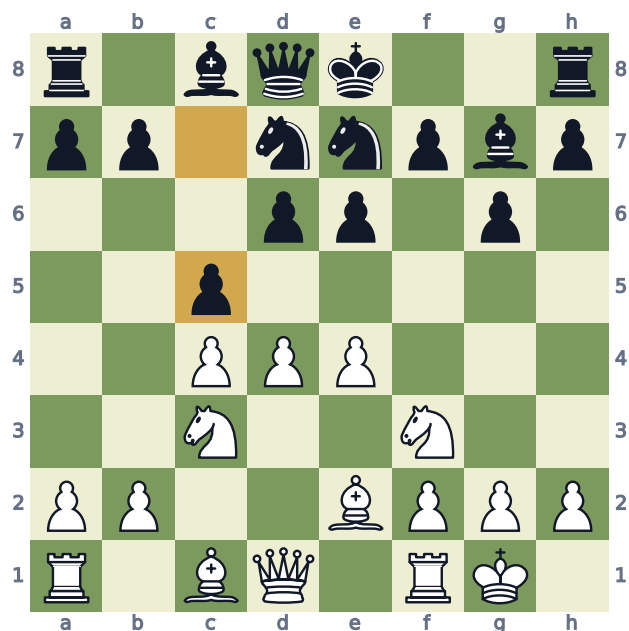
d5 can gain a Benoni-style space advantage.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

c5 asks the base of the center a direct question.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

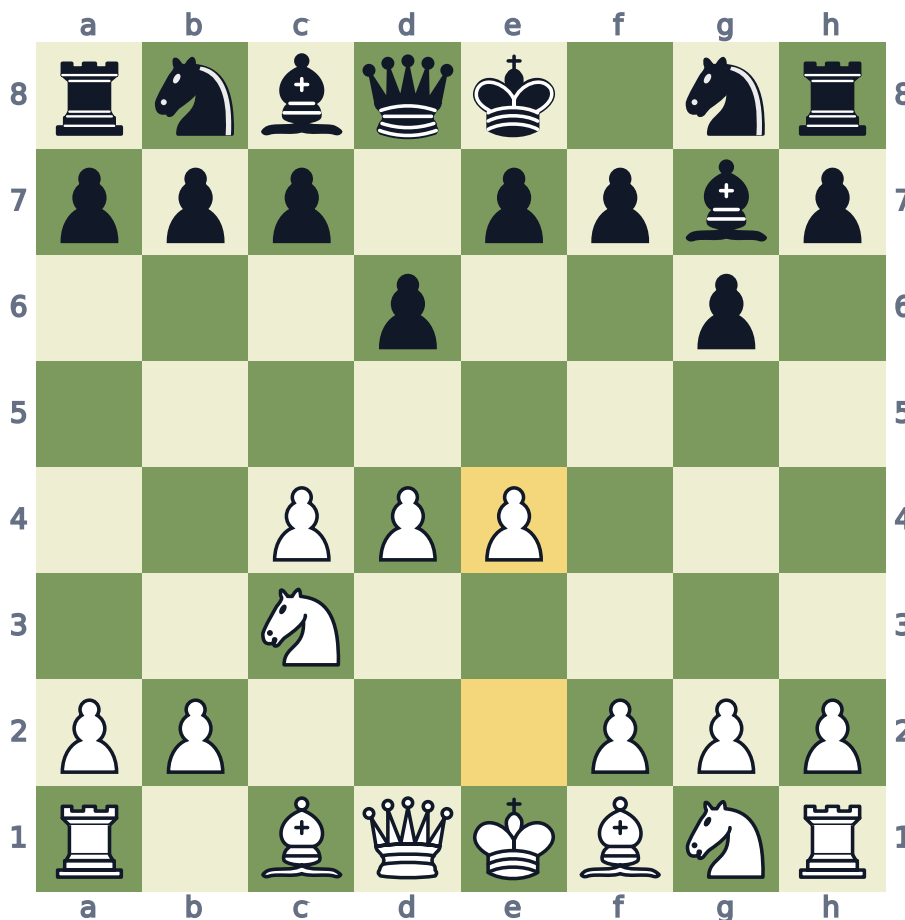
Position estimate: +1.60 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nb5 O-O 2. Nxd6 Qb6 3. dxc5 Nxc5 4. Rb1 a5 5. e5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

c5 against the broad d4 center



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

c5 in a double-fianchetto position



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. Nf3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. O-O Ne7 6. c4 Nd7 7. Nc3 c5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

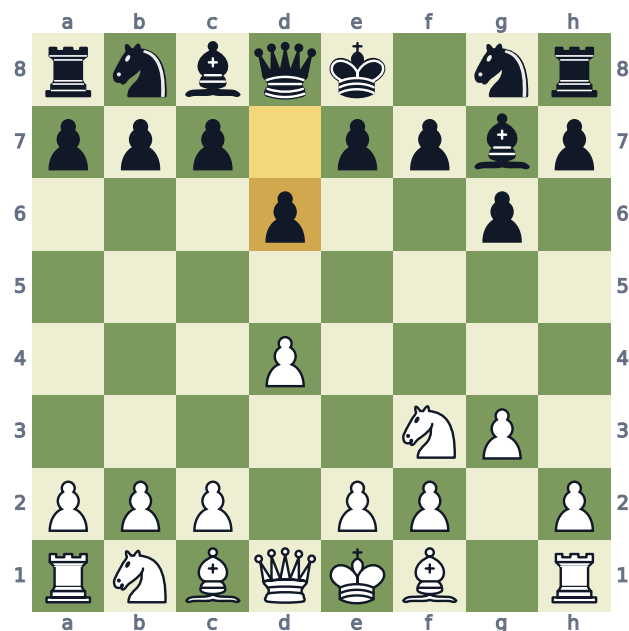
Challenge d4 while both bishops point toward the center.

MAIN DANGER

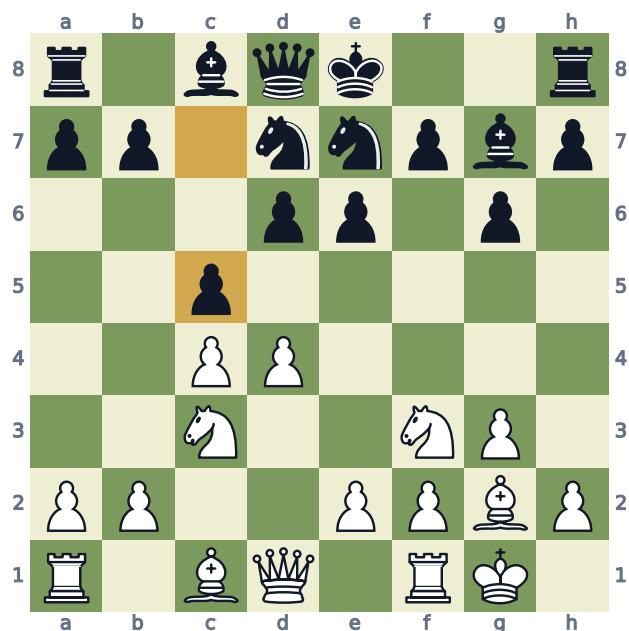
d5 can close Bg7 and give White a protected queenside chain.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

In fianchetto structures, the first useful diagonal often appears after c5.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

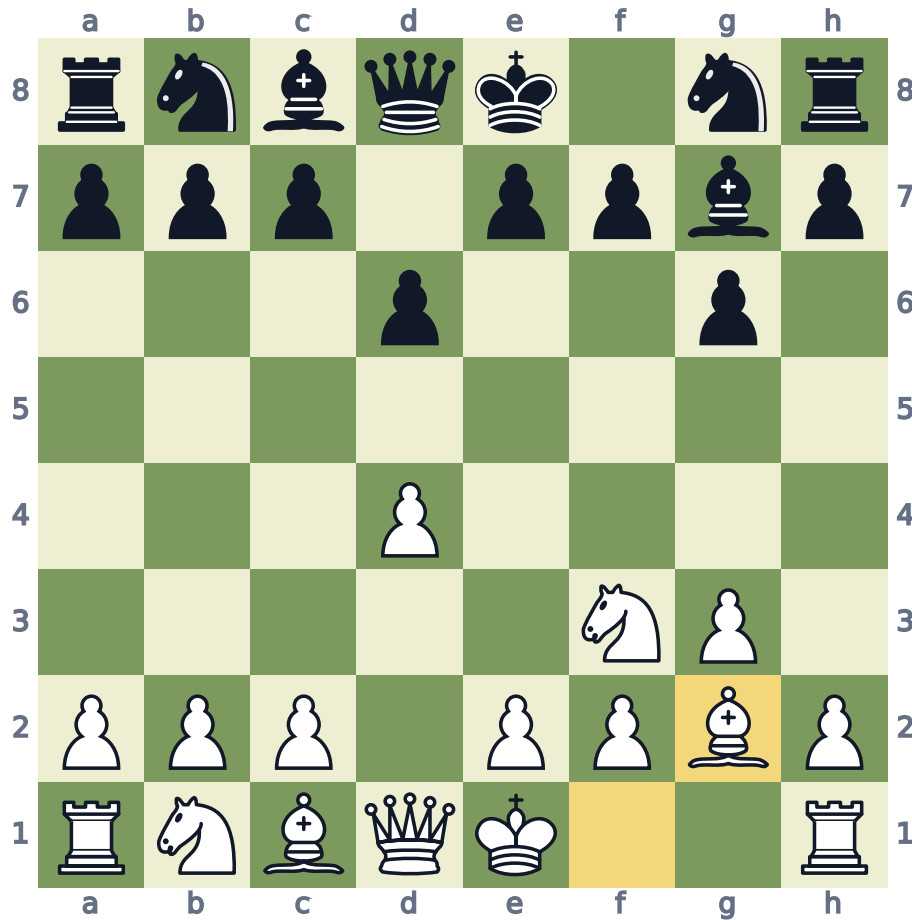
Position estimate: +1.33 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Ne4 O-O 2. Nxd6 Qb6 3. Nxc8 Raxc8 4. d5 exd5 5. cxd5 Nf6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

c5 in a double-fianchetto position



YOUR TASK

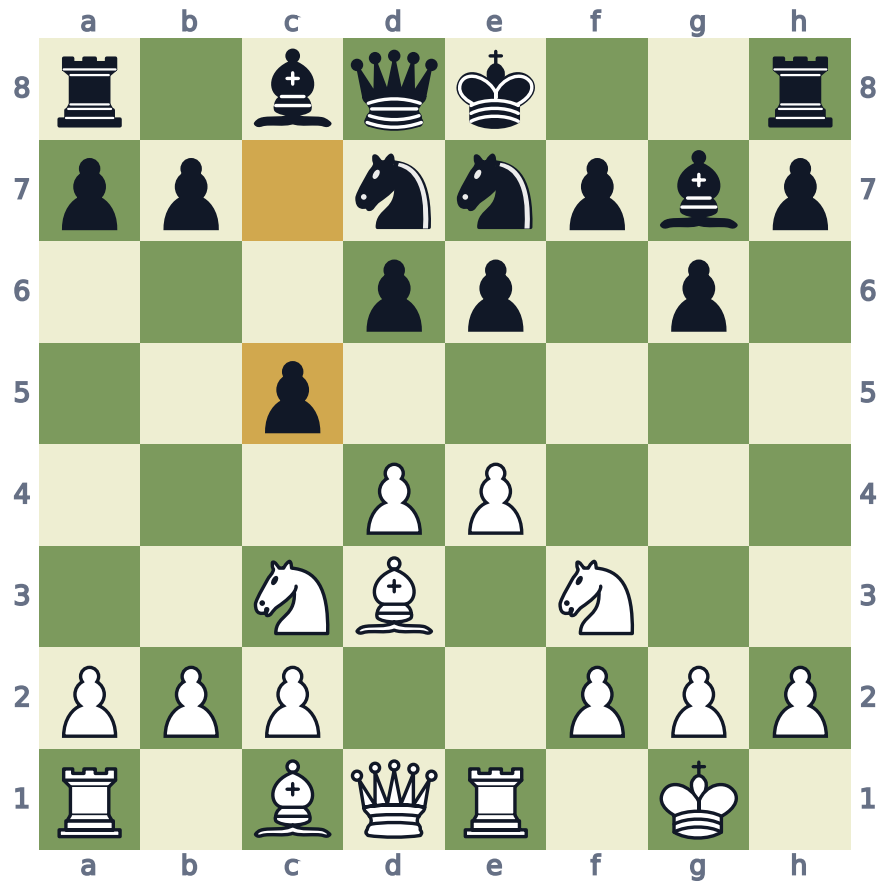
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

c5 against the classical e4 center



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. Nf3 e5 5. Bd3 Ne7 6. O-O Nd7 7. Re1 c5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Pressure d4 and invite a structure Black can attack on the c-file.

MAIN DANGER

d5 may gain space and support e5.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Choose c5 when d4 is less stable than e4.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.31 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. dxc5 dxc5 2. e5 O-O 3. h4 b6 4. Bf4 Bb7 5. Be4 Bxe4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

c5 against the classical e4 center



YOUR TASK

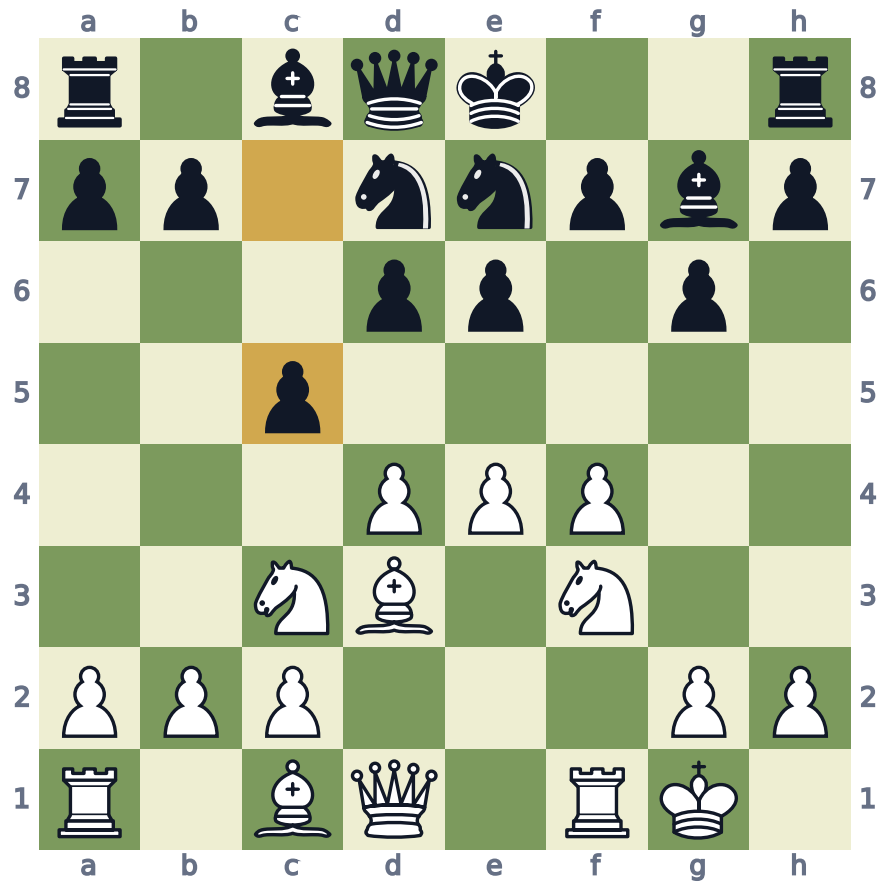
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

c5 against f4



COURSE LINE

1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Bd3 Nd7 7. O-O c5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Attack d4 before White's kingside expansion becomes forcing.

MAIN DANGER

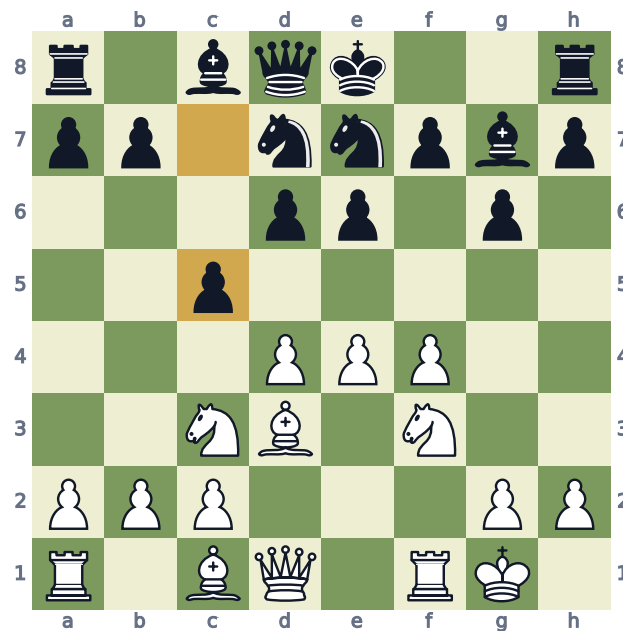
d5 can close the queenside and permit f5.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Central contact is the antidote to wing expansion only when it arrives on time.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

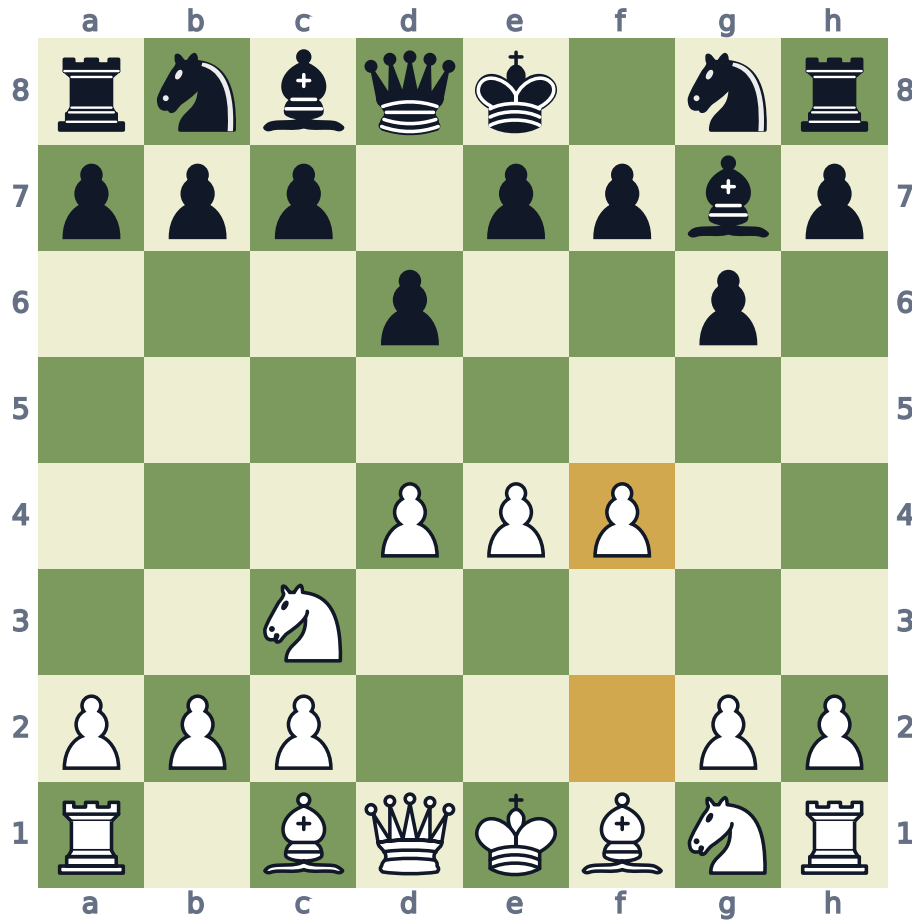
Position estimate: +1.32 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nb5 Qb6 2. a4 O-O 3. a5 Qc6 4. c4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

c5 against f4



YOUR TASK

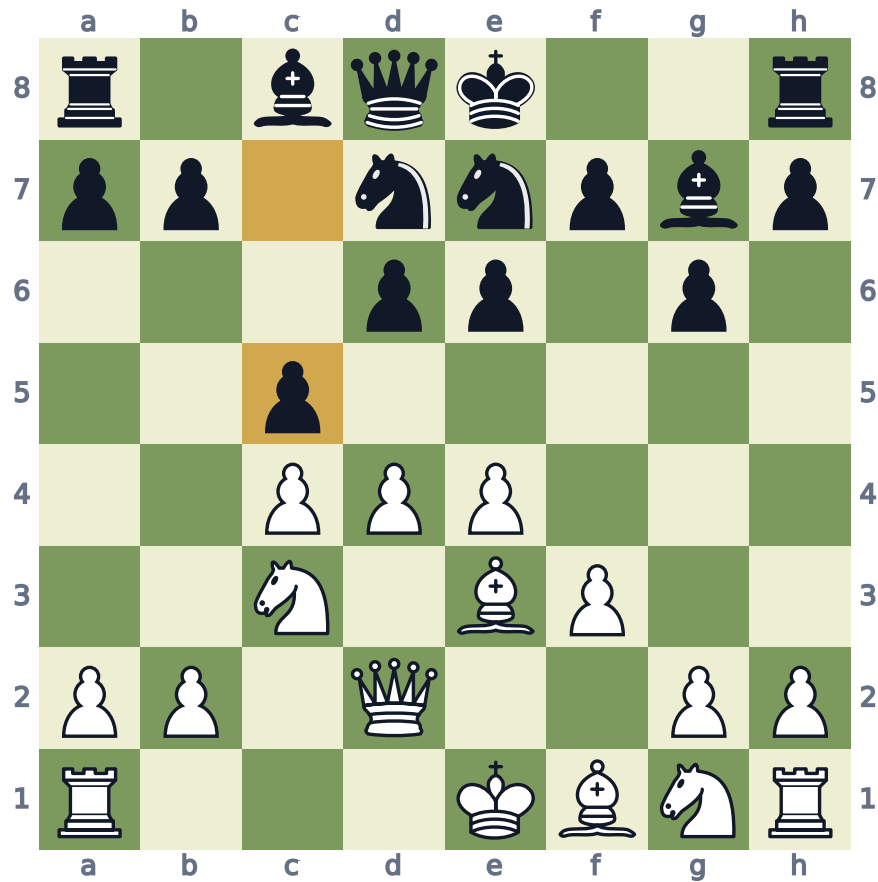
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

c5 against long-castle development



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. e4 e6 5. Be3 Ne7 6. Qd2 Nd7 7. f3 c5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

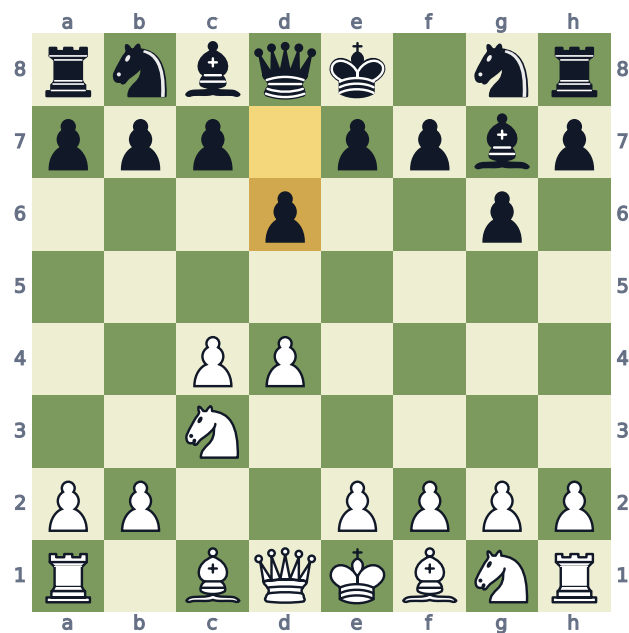
Open queenside lines before White decides where to place the king.

MAIN DANGER

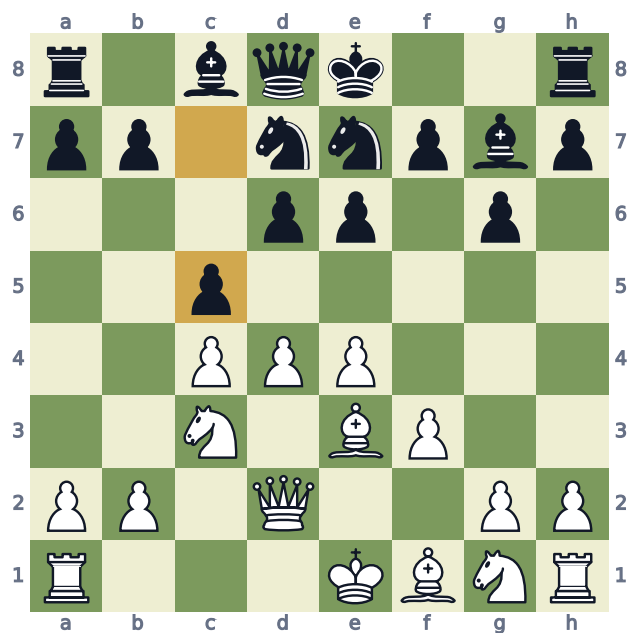
d5 can lock the c-file and give White time for h4.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

If White may castle long, c5 gains an attacking purpose beyond d4.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.10 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. O-O-O Nc6 2. dxc5 dxc5 3. f4 Qa5 4. e5 f6 5. Nf3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

c5 against long-castle development



YOUR TASK

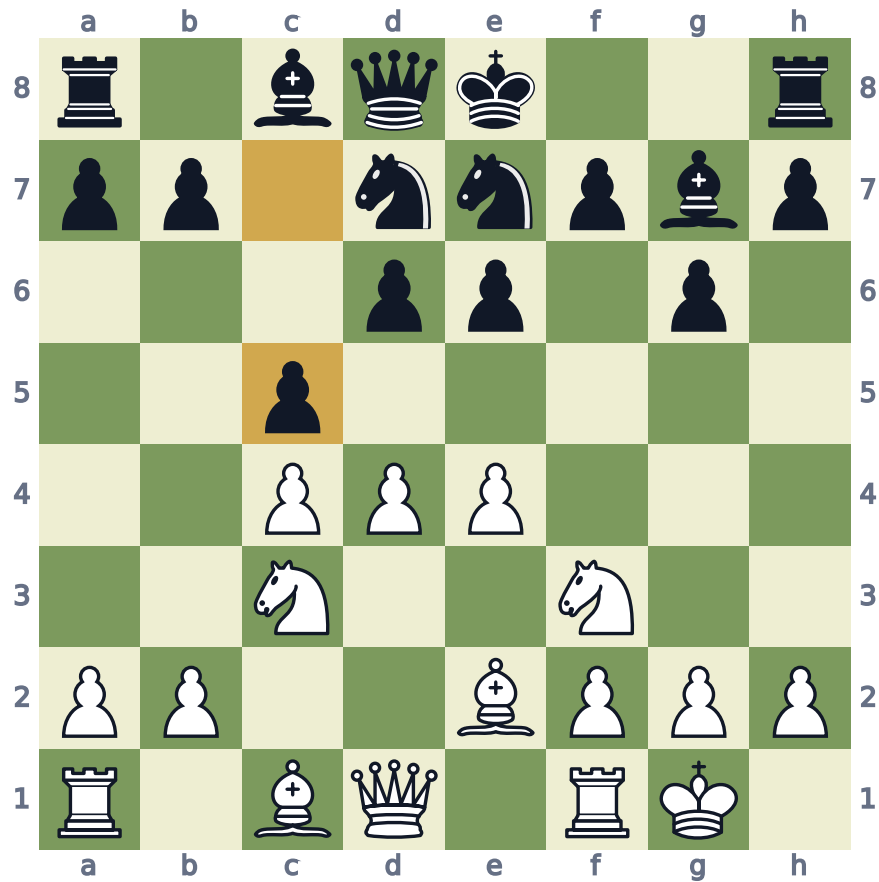
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

c5 after Be2



COURSE LINE

1. d4 g6 2. c4 Bg7 3. e4 d6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. Be2 Nd7 7. O-O c5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

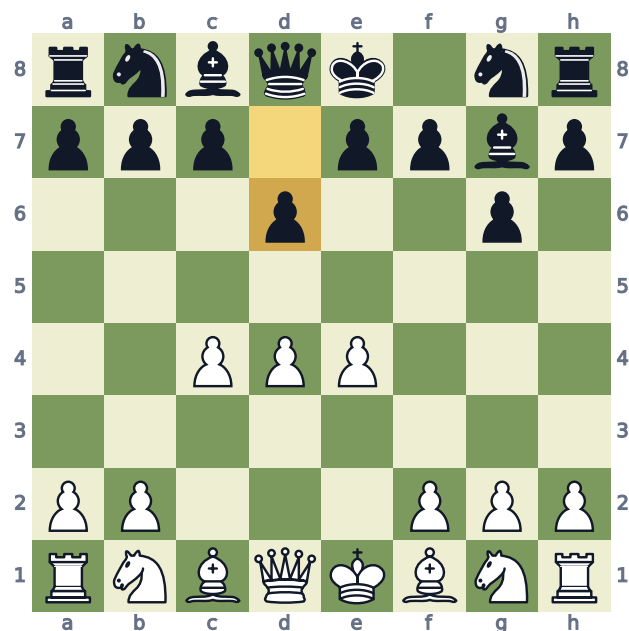
Use the safe king as permission to challenge the center immediately.

MAIN DANGER

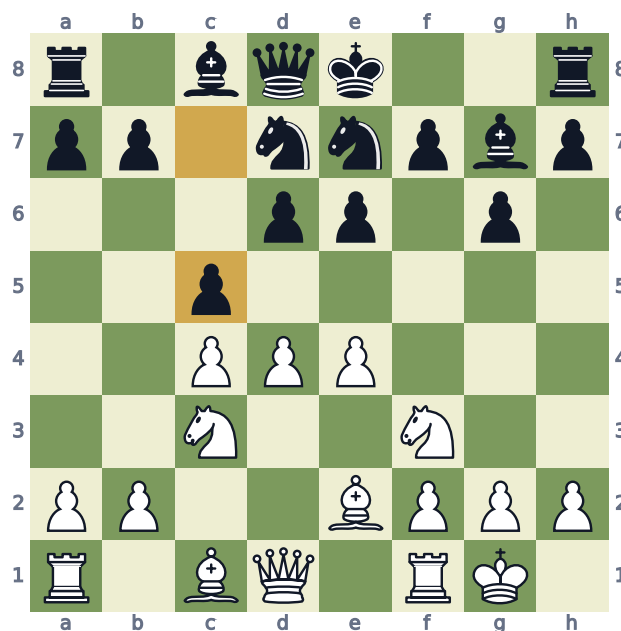
d5 can cramp Ne7 and Nd7 together.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

When both knights are compact, the break must create their next squares.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +1.60 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nb5 O-O 2. Nxd6 Qb6 3. dxc5 Nxc5 4. Rb1 a5 5. e5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

c5 after Be2



YOUR TASK

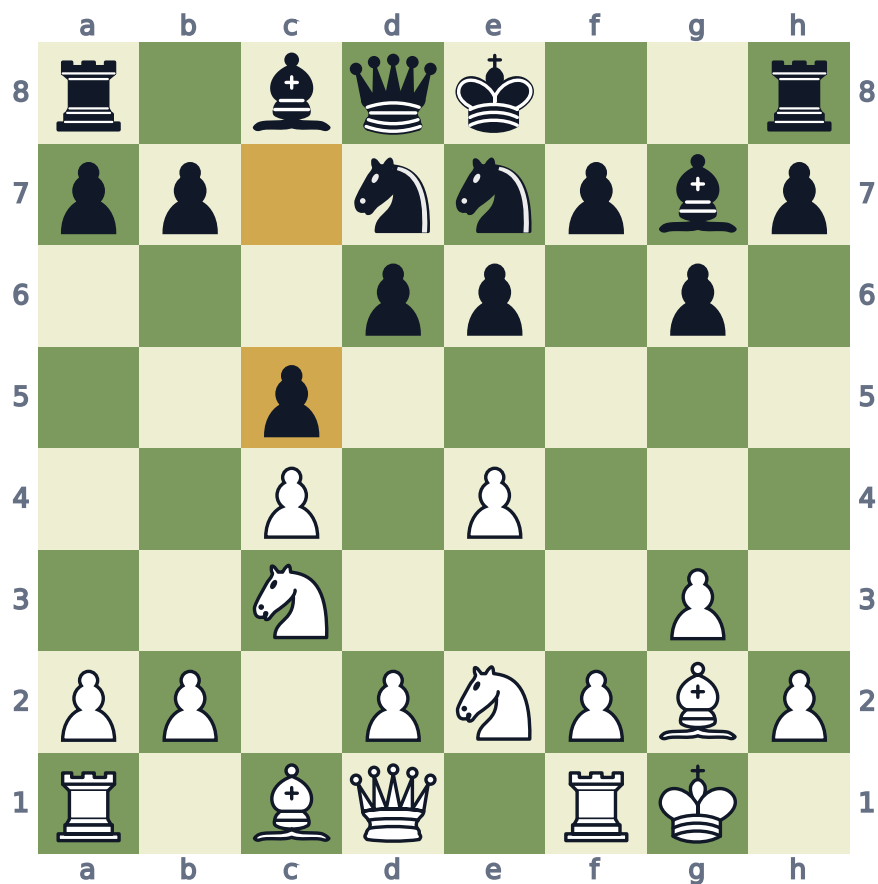
Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

c5 in the English



COURSE LINE

1. c4 g6 2. Nc3 Bg7 3. g3 d6 4. Bg2 e6 5. e4 Ne7 6. Nge2 Nd7 7. O-O c5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Control d4 and prevent White from building the full center for free.

MAIN DANGER

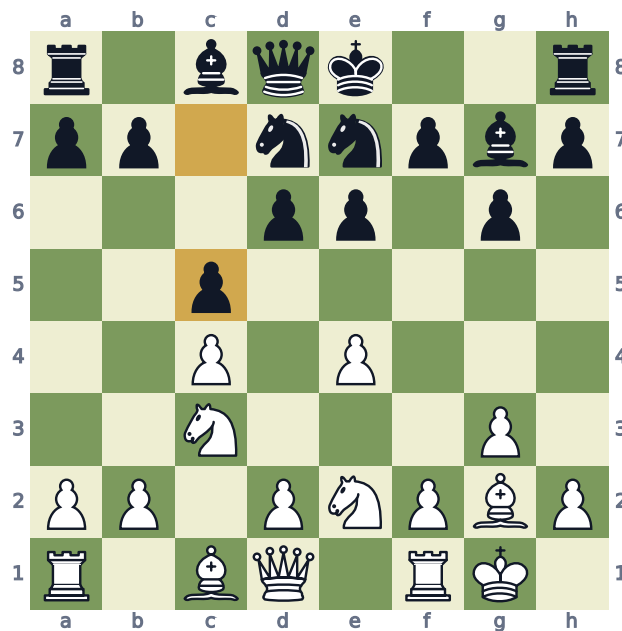
White may use d4 after exchanges or close with d5.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Against c4-e4, c5 fights for d4 before White owns it.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

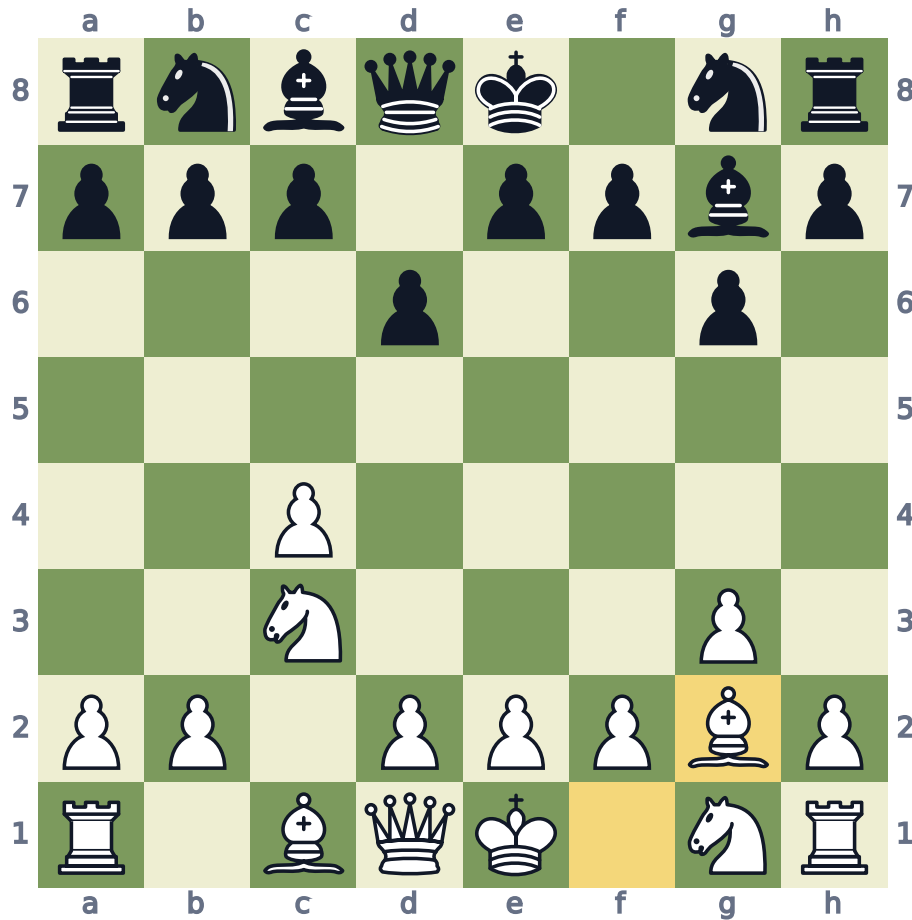
Position estimate: +1.01 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. d4 O-O 2. Bg5 h6 3. Be3 Nc6 4. Qd2 cxd4 5. Nxd4 Nde5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

c5 in the English



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

c5 against a restrained Reti center



COURSE LINE

1. Nf3 g6 2. g3 Bg7 3. Bg2 d6 4. O-O e6 5. d3 Ne7 6. e4 Nd7 7. c3 c5

COURSE-SIDE PLAN

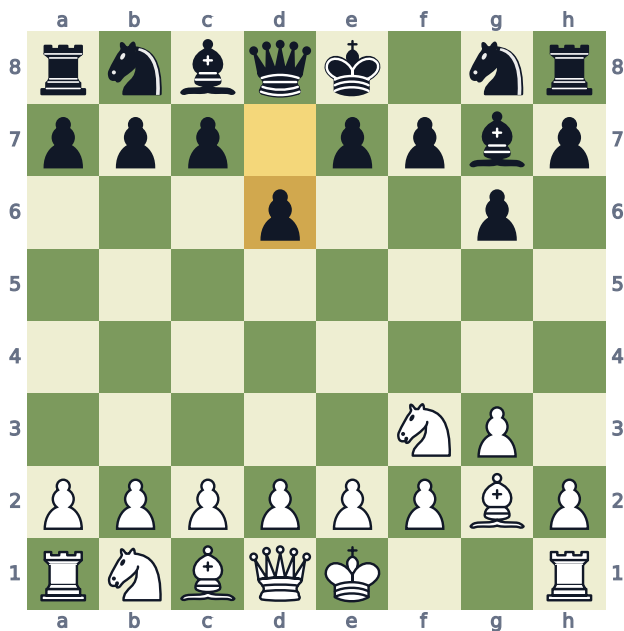
Gain central contact before White expands with d4.

MAIN DANGER

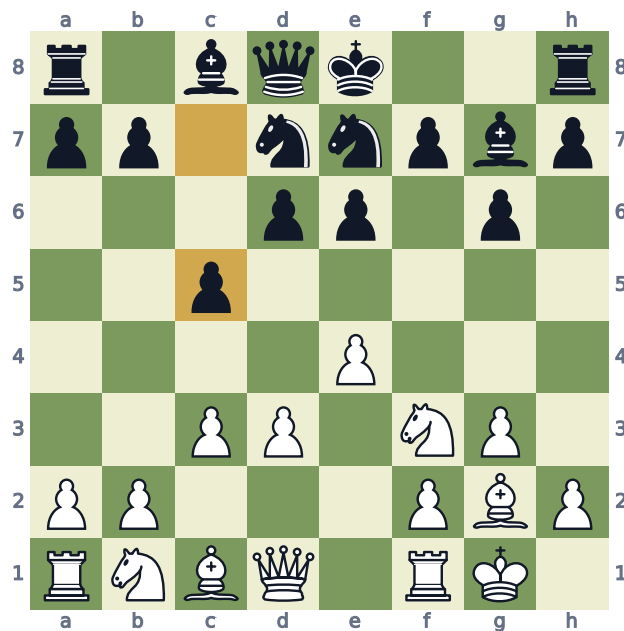
d4 may still arrive with a favorable Maroczy-like structure.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A quiet center should be challenged while its support is incomplete.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

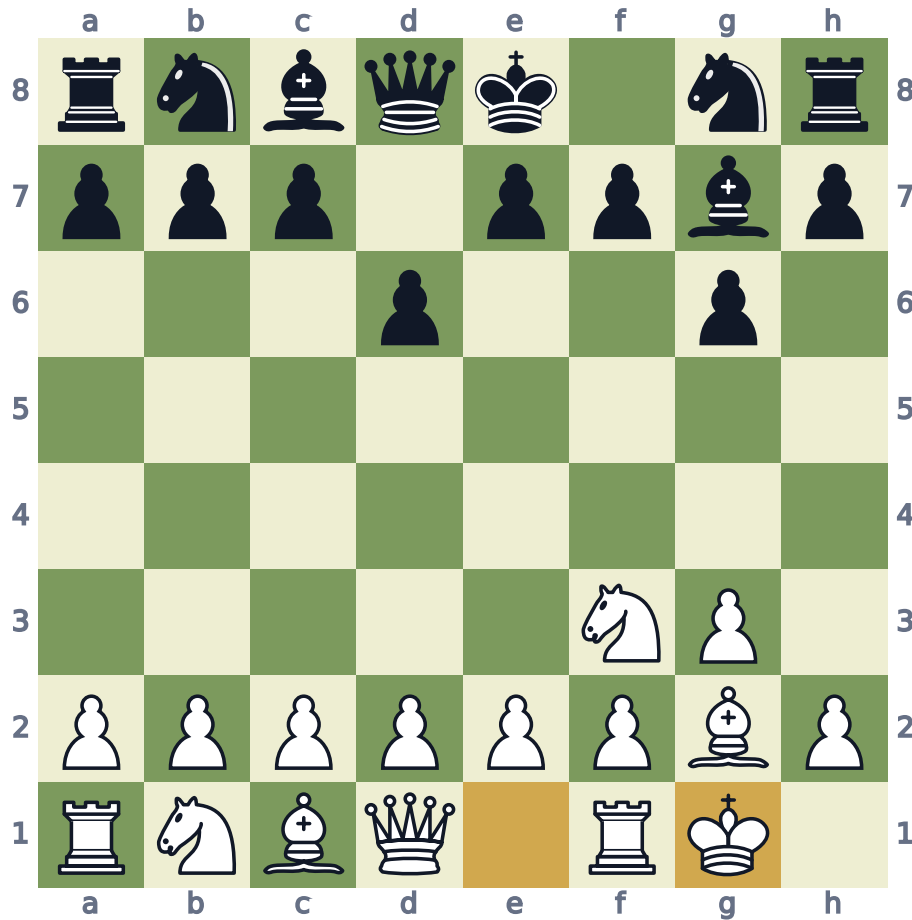
Position estimate: +0.53 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. d4 O-O 2. Bf4 e5 3. dxe5 Nxe5 4. Nxe5 dxe5 5. Bg5 Qe8

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

c5 against a restrained Reti center



YOUR TASK

Black to move. Name the opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give the opponent's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. C5 AGAINST THE BROAD D4 CENTER

Course move: e6. Purpose: Attack d4 and open a queenside route for the rook and queen. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Be3 3. e5 d5 4. Na6 Qd2 5. Ng4 Bxg4 (+0.56 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 can gain a Benoni-style space advantage.

02. C5 IN A DOUBLE-FIANCHETTO POSITION

Course move: e6. Purpose: Challenge d4 while both bishops point toward the center. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 c4 2. Nbd7 Nc3 3. O-O O-O 4. e5 Qc2 5. Re8 Be3 (+0.50 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 can close Bg7 and give White a protected queenside chain.

03. C5 AGAINST THE CLASSICAL E4 CENTER

Course move: e6. Purpose: Pressure d4 and invite a structure Black can attack on the c-file. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be3 2. O-O Qd2 3. Ng4 Bf4 4. c5 dxc5 5. dxc5 h3 (+0.64 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 may gain space and support e5.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. C5 AGAINST F4

Course move: e6. Purpose: Attack d4 before White's kingside expansion becomes forcing. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Nf3 2. O-O Bd3 3. c5 dxc5 4. dxc5 h3 (+0.69 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 can close the queenside and permit f5.

05. C5 AGAINST LONG-CASTLE DEVELOPMENT

Course move: e6. Purpose: Open queenside lines before White decides where to place the king. Engine comparison: 1. Nf6 Be2 2. O-O Be3 3. e5 d5 4. Na6 Qd2 5. Ng4 Bxg4 (+0.56 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 can lock the c-file and give White time for h4.

06. C5 AFTER BE2

Course move: e6. Purpose: Use the safe king as permission to challenge the center immediately. Engine comparison: 1. c5 d5 2. Bxc3+ bxc3 3. e5 f4 4. f5 Nf3 5. fxe4 Ng5 (+0.65 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d5 can cramp Ne7 and Nd7 together.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. C5 IN THE ENGLISH

Course move: e6. Purpose: Control d4 and prevent White from building the full center for free. Engine comparison: 1. Nc6 Rb1 2. a5 d3 3. Nf6 h3 4. O-O a3 5. e6 (+0.34 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: White may use d4 after exchanges or close with d5.

08. C5 AGAINST A RESTRAINED RETI CENTER

Course move: e6. Purpose: Gain central contact before White expands with d4. Engine comparison: 1. e5 e4 2. Nc6 c3 3. Nf6 d4 4. O-O Re1 5. a5 a4 (+0.48 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: d4 may still arrive with a favorable Maroczy-like structure.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.